

Assignment #3 (3): Case Study Analysis

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Introduction

Museums and archives operate as mission-driven cultural heritage institutions that depend heavily on effective leadership, collaborative workplace environments, and responsible governance structures. Because these organizations rely on professional expertise, volunteer engagement, and public trust, organizational culture plays a critical role in their ability to fulfill institutional missions. Research on nonprofit management consistently demonstrates that leadership behavior and workplace climate strongly influence employee engagement, job satisfaction, and organizational effectiveness (Bish & Becker, 2016). When leadership practices undermine trust or respect within the workplace, internal conflict and declining morale can quickly threaten both operational stability and long-term sustainability.

Information organizations such as libraries, archives, and museums are particularly sensitive to leadership and cultural dynamics because their work is highly collaborative and knowledge-based. Evans and Greenwell (2020) note that successful management in these environments requires leaders who foster communication, professional respect, and shared commitment to institutional goals. When these elements are absent, staff morale and organizational performance may decline significantly. Studies of organizational culture within library and information institutions similarly show that employees are more likely to remain engaged and productive when they feel respected and treated as professional equals within the workplace (Glusker et al., 2022).

The situation presented in *Museums and Archives Case 36: Staff Uprising* reflects several interconnected organizational management challenges that are common in nonprofit institutions. Analysis of the case identifies four primary problems: a toxic work environment and declining staff morale, ineffective leadership practices, insufficient governance oversight and performance evaluation processes, and a potential misalignment between financial priorities and nonprofit mission.

Management Problem	Urgency Level
Toxic work environment and staff morale collapse	Very Urgent
Ineffective leadership by the museum director	Urgent
Lack of board oversight and formal performance evaluation	Urgent
Strategic misalignment between financial priorities and nonprofit mission	Not Urgent

Among these issues, the toxic work environment and resulting collapse of staff morale represents the most urgent problem. Organizational culture has a significant impact on employee retention, productivity, and institutional stability, particularly in mission-driven organizations where intrinsic motivation plays an important role in staff engagement (Bish & Becker, 2016;

Glusker et al., 2022). Addressing this issue is therefore essential to restoring workplace stability and creating the conditions necessary to resolve the related leadership and governance challenges facing the organization.

List of the Facts

A clear understanding of the relevant facts is essential for accurately analyzing the organizational problems presented in this case. Not all information provided in the case study is equally important for identifying and addressing the primary issue. Therefore, this section highlights only the key facts that directly relate to the main problem of a toxic workplace environment and the related concerns involving leadership effectiveness and board oversight. These facts provide the factual foundation necessary to understand how the situation developed and why intervention from the governing board is required.

Organizational Context

- The Bartlett County Museum and Archives (BCMA) is a private nonprofit cultural institution whose mission focuses on preserving regional history, providing public access to information, supporting research, and offering educational programs.
- The organization employs approximately 24.7 full-time equivalent staff members, including several professional archivists and librarians.
- The museum also relies on a large number of volunteers and docents to support operations and public services.
- BCMA maintains extensive archival and historical collections and serves thousands of researchers annually.

Governance and Leadership

- The museum is governed by a board composed of local government representatives and appointed community members.
- Lenard Morgan serves as the chair of the governing board and has been on the board for approximately six years.
- The museum's director, Courtney, has been in her position for just over two years.
- During Courtney's tenure, the board has primarily focused on improvements in the museum's financial condition.

Staff Complaint

- Morgan receives a confidential letter addressed to him and delivered internally rather than through the postal service.
- The letter includes a cover letter, a page of signatures, and supporting documents outlining staff concerns.

- The signature page contains a large number of names, suggesting that more than half of the staff have signed the complaint.
- Some signatories identify themselves as volunteers or docents, indicating that the concerns extend beyond paid staff members.

Allegations in the Letter

The staff letter outlines four major concerns regarding the director's leadership:

- Staff members express a lack of confidence in the director's ability to effectively lead the museum.
- The director is accused of creating a hostile or toxic work environment.
- Staff believe the director places excessive emphasis on monetizing museum activities, which they feel conflicts with the nonprofit mission of the institution.
- Staff allege that the director has lost her temper and verbally reprimanded employees publicly, including incidents occurring in visitor galleries.

Additional points raised in the complaint include:

- Staff state that morale within the organization is extremely low or "nonexistent."
- Staff report that they consulted with a labor attorney regarding the difference between bullying and a legally defined hostile work environment and believe both elements may be present.
- The staff formally request that the governing board investigate the situation.

Board Awareness and Oversight Issues

- Prior to receiving the letter, Morgan had heard informal staff complaints about the director but had interpreted them as typical workplace dissatisfaction.
- Morgan recalls a conversation in which the director stated that every staff member had disappointed her at least once and suggested that staff lacked professionalism and understanding of the museum's financial realities.
- Morgan did not follow up on this conversation at the time.
- After reading the complaint, Morgan realizes that the board has not conducted a formal performance review of the director.
- He is also uncertain whether the museum has a structured performance evaluation process for staff members.

Potential Organizational Risk

- Morgan recognizes that the large number of staff and volunteers involved suggests a serious internal problem.

- He also expresses concern that the issue could become public if staff speak to reporters, potentially damaging the museum's reputation.

Taken together, these facts indicate that the Bartlett County Museum and Archives is facing a significant internal management crisis. A large portion of staff members and volunteers have formally expressed concerns about leadership behavior, workplace culture, and organizational priorities. The scale of the complaint, combined with allegations of hostile behavior and the apparent absence of formal performance evaluation processes, suggests that the issue has developed over time without adequate oversight. These facts establish the context necessary for analyzing potential solutions and determining the most appropriate course of action for the museum's governing board.

Alternative Courses of Action

The first alternative course of action is one mentioned by Lenard Morgan in the case study: A 360 managerial review technique. Feedback, which can be gained from such a review, is important for employees of all levels as it can "provide valuable insight into both an employee's strengths and areas of opportunity" (Towe, n.d.). As Lenard Morgan noted, he does not believe that a formal review was ever conducted on Director Courtney. A 360 review may be helpful because it covers a broad range of workplace-related competencies, and the responses are obtained through confidential and anonymous evaluations from those who regularly interact with the individual.

Another course of action, although less likely to succeed, is a leadership or governance reform. A leadership reform involves replacing or reassigning leadership to make a change at the top of an organization. Depending on the organization and the leader(s) to be replaced, the organization may let leaders go or, if covered by merit laws, they may need to reassign staff to new organizations. As the toxic work environment at the Bartlett Museum can be most attributed to Courtney and how she treats her staff, a change in leadership may fix that toxic environment.

Core values are an important part of the organizational culture of an organization. As the work environment of the Bartlett Museum is very toxic, realigning the museum's core values may be a good step for change. However, by working to realign these values, leadership needs to ensure that the values result in concrete changes and are not just a stunt for public relations. Many times, toxic environments result from the gap between stated values and actual behavior. During this course of action, leaders (and the Board) would work with staff at all levels to determine what values need improved, which ones should change, and whether any new values would enhance the work culture. By realigning the core values of the Bartlett Museum, and allowing their input, staff will feel heard and respected and feel that they have a say in the organization's culture.

The next course of action would be to empower the Board to intervene. The Board at the Bartlett Museum, from reading the case study, does not appear to work closely with the staff of

the museum. This can be noted by their lack of knowledge about the issues at the museum, and Lenard Morgan's dismissal of Courtney's comment on the usefulness of her staff. The Board should have power over the organization; however, they do not take advantage of that to make changes. By empowering the Board to intervene in the activities of the organization, they can work to fix the toxic environment that plagues the museum. The Board needs to understand that they have the power and sway to make changes that could benefit the Museum and its staff, and they can do this with the faith of that staff.

Another course of action to recommend is bringing in an external consultant or firm. Many organizations employ their own internal consultants who work in the human resources department. However, it is not noted whether the Bartlett Museum employs an internal consultant or even has an HR department. It is very likely that the Museum does not have HR as the letter from the employees went directly to the Board instead of filtering through the applicable department. A consultant is a professional who offers "advice and guidance to businesses, charities, companies or organizations to help improve their productivity, aid in conflict resolution, and develop plans for increased productivity and staff satisfaction" (Indeed Editorial Team, 2025). An external consultant is one who is not employed by the organization, and they can bring in outside resources and assist with identifying and solving problems that may be missed otherwise.

The final recommended course of action would be hiring an assistant to the Director. As Director, Courtney currently handles all the managerial tasks that are required to successfully run the museum. However, she appears to focus only on the financial aspects and is not the best at working with the staff under her due to her toxic personality. In this case, an assistant could be hired to handle the day-to-day activities of the museum, which would allow Courtney to focus on the governing and financial parts of her position. Assistant managers typically work in the areas of leadership and team management, operational and administrative duties, customer service, and strategic planning and execution ("Core Functions", 2025). To eliminate the need for Courtney to interact with staff, which would remove the degradation and shouting she is prone to, her assistant would handle the staff and visitor ("customer") interactions.

Advantages and Disadvantages

360 Managerial Review

The 360 Managerial Review is a very useful process for capturing a full comprehensive evaluation of an employee's performance from multiple perspectives to gain better insight of both workplace behavior and professional competencies. The advantages of a 360 Managerial review are that feedback is collected anonymously from multiple people at various levels of the organization like supervisors, peers, and direct reports to get a sense of how the employee being reviewed interacts at all levels throughout the organization. The feedback gathered covers multiple categories of competencies deemed important in the workplace and is gathered and

tabulated by category to show exactly where there is room for improvement, helping to create a clear and concise development plan for the employee being reviewed (Custom Insight, 2026).

Like any other process, there are disadvantages. The 360 Managerial Review must be properly utilized and taken seriously for it to be effective. If a 360 Managerial Review is conducted, but the organization doesn't properly implement the results, then data collected during the process goes to waste as nothing will really change with the employee's performance. Another disadvantage is that, like all things involving data, there is room for bias. If evaluations provided are biased or too vague, that data isn't truly helpful. "Biased reviews feed inequity loops because these reviews determine how people get paid and who gets promoted" (Roy, 2021). Therefore, organizations must be very intentional of how they conduct 360 Managerial Reviews for them to benefit the workplace.

Leadership and Governance Reform

In this situation one of the advantages of replacing or reassigning Courtney is that a large number of the staff and some volunteers have come together to show just how dissatisfied they are with the way she has been managing the organization and treating volunteers and members of the staff. They've as a collective shown how they lack confidence in her work and ability to align with the organization's culture and have also expressed how hostile they find the work environment. Replacing or reassigning Courtney would avoid any potential legal actions and would quickly provide a solution for dealing with the discontent. Courtney would be gone and the staff would be appeased.

However, one of the largest disadvantages to this solution is that replacing or reassigning her is more of a quick fix and doesn't really solve any of the deep institutional issues that have been brought to attention with this situation. The organization currently isn't properly equipped to deal with conflict or negative situations. They don't have the implemented framework needed to handle what happens when someone within the organization isn't performing properly, and without this framework there is nothing stopping this situation from occurring in the future.

Rearticulate Core Values

The advantages of rearticulating the core values of the Bartlett Museum ensure there is not a gap between what the museum lists as its values versus how the institution operates. As Evans and Greenwell state, "there should be a dynamic interaction between assessing the organizational environment and reviewing the mission and vision statements" (2020, pp. 95). By reevaluating vague organizational language and strengthening the wording used in areas like the mission or value statement, the organization can rearticulate their core values. Stronger, clearer, and more concise mission, vision and value statements ensure that there isn't any room for interpretation or confusion regarding what the organization sees as its purpose. Rearticulating core values with clearer statements guarantees that the organization doesn't fall into another situation where a director places finances over the values of the institution.

The disadvantage of rearticulating core values is that it is a slow, iterative process. Rearticulating the core values by editing the mission, vision or value statements requires multiple rounds of back-and-forth conversation and edits between the board and members of the staff to determine which values fully capture the culture and purpose of the institution. While this course of action is important in reshaping the culture of the work environment, it is not the most fitting solution to address the urgency of the situation.

Board Intervention

One of the advantages of having the board step in is that, for Lenard it puts the onus of decision making on the larger overarching collective with higher positions of power. As the board, they can provide a top-down solution from an outside bird's eye view that looks at the organization as a whole. Being a bit more removed from the situation, but understanding how the museum operates, they can assess how to move forward in a way that best benefits the institution.

A disadvantage, however, is the case study indicates that the board might be a bit too far removed from understanding how the museum operates. The board seems not to be very tied into what is happening within the organization as they weren't aware that this was an ongoing issue, and they haven't at all checked in with how Courtney is operating since she was hired two years ago. The board might not be the most useful in assessing what is best in this situation because they've been too far removed from the operational aspects of the museum.

External Consultant or Firm

Having an external consultant come in to perform human resources duties allows for a fresh set of eyes from someone that specializes in managing conflict in the workplace. The advantage of this external consultant is that they are a neutral third party that takes into account the organizational goals and legal implication of large decision making when handling complaints while also removing the risk of favoritism or a conflict of interest that an internal consultant might bring. An outside opinion can also help to protect internal workplace relationships since the situation is being handled by a professional outsider (Dynamic Corporate Solutions Inc., n.d.).

A disadvantage of this is that it might take a while to get in an external consultant to come in, assess the entirety of the situation and then deliver a solution. Another disadvantage is that the outside firm might not fully grasp the culture of the organization, leading to a solution this is unsatisfactory for the people involved.

Hire An Assistant

An advantage of hiring an assistant to the Director is that they could absorb the role of working more closely with and managing the staff and volunteers. It is evident that Courtney struggles with her duty of managing staff and having an assistant to the Director who serves as

the intermediary could help relieve some of the tension that's built from Courtney and the staff working so closely together. This would allow Courtney to focus more closely on the financial aspect of the museum which she strives at.

The disadvantages, however, are that this requires additional funding to support the salary of a managerial role, and Courtney might not react well to having someone come in and take over part of her job responsibilities. The largest disadvantage to this course of action is that it doesn't at all address Courtney's behavior in the workplace that has led to a toxic work environment. Hiring an Assistant to the Director places Courtney further away from the staff but doesn't rectify the way she's mistreated them.

Certainty of Occurrence

The certainty of occurrence reflects both internal and external factors that would affect the probability of the desired outcome for each respective alternative. For the context of the percentage of chance, I will be specifically noting the percentage of likelihood of occurrence based on the assumed priorities established in the case study, as opposed to the percentage the alternative would succeed in the best outcome. For that, each alternative has advantages and disadvantages that should be weighed against each other before diagnosing the best alternative.

In the case study, Leonard Morgan mentions a few concerns to immediately be addressed which should be considered to identify Bartlett County Museum & Archive's Board's priorities in order to determine corrective courses of action. As the chair of the museum's governing board, this gives us insight into which alternative actions are more likely to occur.

In the case study, we can deduce priorities from some of the comments made by the chief board member:

"It really is my fault and to some extent, the board's responsibility, to monitor Operations."

He feels directly responsible and guilty for the lack of leadership, accountability, and communication. He also mentions he regrets not following up with Courtney, and takes the defensive stance that she has not come to him with anything, so how could he have known?

"Just when I thought the museum had turned the corner—well, at least the financial corner—this has to happen."

He mentions the positive aspect of seeing finances 'turn a corner', which we can deduce as a positive outcome, which may deter certain alternatives, like reassigning Courtney.

"If I don't acknowledge the letter quickly there is a good chance someone will talk to a reporter."

An imminent concern is the employees going public with their complaints, meaning whatever alternative is decided must happen quickly. He also says he doesn't want the press to get involved at all if possible.

“After the quick review, it was clear this was a major concern, perhaps even about the community’s long-term view of the museum.”

He is obviously very concerned with the public image of the museum. He mentions he had heard some internal grumblings but had brushed them off because there had been no formal complaints. He is obviously very concerned whether those negative views are happening outside of the organization too.

From insight into these priorities, we can keep this in mind when determining the percentages of likelihood of occurrence of each alternative corrective course of action.

Alternative Courses of Action	Advantages	Disadvantages	Evaluation of Advantages and Disadvantages	CoO %
360 Managerial Review	<i>-Complete analysis -Identify all concerns</i>	<i>-Must follow Through -Biases</i>	<i>-Data could be unhelpful -Create cyclical issues</i>	100%
Leadership/Governance Reform	<i>-Avoid legal action from employees -Fix lack of confidence</i>	<i>-Ignores foundational issues -Unknown new leadership</i>	<i>-Appeases employees -Only a short-term solution</i>	10%
Rearticulate Core Values	<i>-Realigns priorities</i>	<i>-Slow/arduous process</i>	<i>-Would take too long -Ensures goals are met</i>	50%
Board Intervention	<i>-Outside POV -Highest authority</i>	<i>-Uninformed for too long</i>	<i>-May make unnecessary corrections</i>	80%
External Consult/Firm	<i>-Specialized help -Unbiased</i>	<i>-Solution may be unsatisfactory -Potential cost</i>	<i>-Could take too much time -May make employee culture worse</i>	20%
Hire an Assistant	<i>-Act as middle-man -Disperses tension</i>	<i>-Potentially insulting -Cost of additional salary</i>	<i>-Courtney still controls finances -Employees happy</i>	25%

360 Managerial Review (100% chance)

This is the very first thing Lenard Morgan thinks of and says he will look into. This also solves the majority of the problems thoroughly, while collecting more information. The most

crucial step this stage is to communicate openly with your employees to gain more information, something that could have prevented this situation. As someone in a managerial position, this is a defining decision going forward. If that decision leads to a negative outcome, it could be a mistake, but if the negative outcome is caused by a lack of information or asking questions, that is not a mistake; it is negligence.

Leadership/Governance Reform (10% chance)

While this may be a quick solution to appease the employees and avoid legal action, there is still a potential risk of legal action from Courtney without pre-communicated grounds for suspension. Notifying her would require long-term, clearly defined performance expectations not being met, if they are an ethical organization. Additionally, they would have to go through the rehiring process for a replacement, which is a long process and may worsen the work culture.

Reararticulate Core Values (50% chance)

There is a high likelihood this would happen, just not immediately. It would not meet the urgency required by this situation and would require being paired with a faster solution in order to prevent the employees from further harming the reputation of the museum with the public. It could likely be done in conjunction with a 360 review, after the needs of the museum are identified, or once the employees are satisfied with the actions taken by the Board.

Board Intervention (80% chance)

Although it is of my personal opinion that this may not be the best course of action, this is a very high probability. When suddenly faced with a large-scale issue like this, it is very likely the board will meet and to decide the best corrective action they can quickly implement, and utilize their authority, due to the priority of a solution as a high urgency. Leonard Morgan immediately wants to call an emergency meeting, which also fulfills the personal priority of sharing the responsibility, while simultaneously delegating some of the guilt he mentions feeling to the other members he knows were also unaware, which is both validating and also benefits him by getting more opinions and ideas of solutions.

External Consult/Firm (20% chance)

In a situation where the board has been blindsided by this issue, they are likely to turn to researching solutions. If the external consultant's advertising is good enough, they are likely to come across this option. It has less of a chance of consideration, though, due to the cost and the amount of time it would take.

Hire an Assistant (25% chance)

This solution would solve majority of the issues, but it would also take a very hands-on approach that would be uncharacteristic of the Board so far. It would also cost another salary, which they may be able to afford if they continue to have Courtney run the finances, but it would

make this option less likely. They would have to be extremely careful about proposing this idea to Courtney, to avoid insulting her ability to lead the team effectively, and should be careful to present it as an opportunity to continue what she enjoys and is good at, instead of a demotion of responsibility.

Best Alternative

The best alternative would be to conduct a 360 Managerial Review, then, with the evidence collected from the review, use that to inform a rearticulation of the core values of the Bartlett Museum. The immediate urgency would be addressed by a 360 Review, and it would let the employees feel heard while utilizing the Board's authority and reestablishing their reach and responsibility of the museum and staff. It would also give more time to the Board to meet and discuss alternative actions with their findings, while showing the employees they are listening and responding, building trust and buy-in for an eventual solution. This would also benefit the Board greatly, by getting an anonymous, honest opinion of each staff member's experiences to make a better-informed decision on the necessary foundations that need to be established from a full investigation. This can be discussed in further meetings and voted on to better support and establish values. The mission statement does not necessarily have to change, but potentially, an additional value of supporting the staff with clearly defined expectations and values for the staff to follow, for example, creating a more involved HR department and having accessible, clearly communicated financial goals. That way, it prevents any future issues if an employee (or manager) is not following the clearly defined expectations; it is no surprise when corrective action needs to be taken. This also is the best financial decision for the Board, as both options are things that can be solved internally at very little cost.

Group Strategies and Responsibilities

The strategies we used to follow the steps of the assignment started with analyzing the problems laid out in the case study for the first part of the assignment. Then, before starting each assignment part, we met over TEAMS to lay out the main steps/parts while designating sections for each member. We continued to meet weekly to go over parts that were completed to review them prior to moving on and/or submitting. We also continued to update the Gantt chart as sections were completed and adjusted due dates as needed, which helped to keep us on track for assignment completion.

To make the assignments fair to each member, we worked together to decide who would complete which sections. Each member was then responsible for their specific sections. During each of our review meetings we would look over each other's sections to make sure the content made sense and flowed together before submission. When deciding who was going to do which part, we volunteered based on our interests and strengths, so no one was stuck with a section they weren't interested in.

During our last meeting we discussed the strengths and contributions of each member. We all expressed our gratefulness for pulling each other as group members because we all got along, and everyone contributed fairly to each of the assignment parts. Every member was committed to sticking to the timeline we laid out, and every member attended each of the TEAMS meetings and contributed with their thoughts and ideas. Overall, we valued each member's individual input and the work that they put into their sections of the assignments.

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